Simple Expense Tracker – Product Requirements Document (PRD)

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1. Overview

The product is a very simple daily expense tracker: log "₹10 auto" in under 5 seconds, see a weekly report, and stay inside a self-set spending limit. It launches as a web app first, then Android and iOS.

Problem. Most expense apps add bank sync, investments, bill splitting and deep budgeting. Everyday users find them complicated and stop logging within days. Small daily spends (auto, tea, snacks) are the ones that quietly add up, and they are the ones people forget.

Vision. The simplest way for anyone in India to know where their money went, and to cut unnecessary spending.

Target users. Students, first-job earners, daily-wage and gig workers, homemakers and anyone who has never used a budgeting app.

Goals

- Add an expense in 5 seconds or less, with no category picking.
- Show a weekly report that can be understood in 10 seconds.
- Let users set weekly, monthly and yearly limits and warn them gently.
- Help users separate needs from wants.
- Work the same on web, Android and iOS using one backend.

Non-goals (v1)

- Bank or SMS reading, UPI sync, investments, loans.
- Shared or family accounts, bill splitting.
- Multi-currency (v1 is INR only; the currency is stored so it can be added later).
- Receipt scanning and AI advice.

2. Personas and user stories

Persona	Who they are	What they need
Ravi, 20	College student, spends ₹200–400 a day on bus, food and recharge	Notice small leaks like tea, snacks and subscriptions before month end
Sunita, 38	Homemaker, handles household cash	Log in Hindi, see how much of the month's limit is left
Imran, 27	Gig delivery rider, irregular income	Log in two taps, keep a weekly cap
Priya, 24	First-job professional	Find out how much goes to wants vs needs

User stories

1. As a user, I enter an amount and item name and tap Add, so that my spend is saved in seconds.
2. As a user, I tap a quick-add chip such as Auto ₹10, so that repeated spends take one tap.
3. As a user, I mark an expense as Need or Want, so that I can see my unnecessary spending.
4. As a user, I set a weekly, monthly or yearly limit, so that I know when I am close to overspending.
5. As a user, I see a warning at 80% and 100% of a limit, so that I can slow down in time.
6. As a user, I open a weekly report, so that I understand my spending without reading a table.
7. As a user, I see a dashboard with three charts, so that I can spot patterns.
8. As a user, I edit, delete and undo an entry, so that typing mistakes are easy to fix.
9. As a user, I use the app without signing up, so that I can start immediately and sign in later to back up my data.
10. As a user, I switch the app language to Hindi, so that I am comfortable using it.

3. Functional requirements

Priority: P0 = must ship in the first release, P1 = soon after, P2 = later.

ID	Feature	Requirement	Priority
F1	Quick add	One screen with amount, item name and an Add button. Amount accepts whole numbers and decimals up to 2 places. Date defaults to today and can be changed.	P0
F2	Quick-add chips	Show the user's most frequent items (for example Auto, Tea, Lunch) as one-tap chips with the last used amount. New users start with 6 default chips.	P0
F3	Auto-category	Guess a category from the item name using a keyword list (auto → Travel, samosa → Food). The user can change it with one tap. Unknown names go to Other.	P0
F4	Need / Want tag	Each expense has a Need or Want tag. Default is Need; categories can carry a default tag.	P0
F5	Edit, delete, undo	Edit any field, delete with a 5-second Undo, and see a recent list on the home screen.	P0
F6	Limits	Set an optional limit for week, month and year. Each limit can be edited or removed. Week starts on Monday (configurable).	P0
F7	Limit alerts	Show progress bars. Show a gentle in-app message at 80% and 100% of any limit. No blocking and no guilt-heavy wording.	P0
F8	Weekly report	Total spent, top 3 expenses, biggest category, Need vs Want split, daily bar summary, and change vs last week (up or down in ₹ and %).	P0
F9	Dashboard	Exactly three visuals: spending by category, daily spending bars, and limit progress. Switchable between week, month and year.	P0
F10	Guest mode	Full use without an account. Data is stored on the device first.	P0
F11	Account and sync	Optional sign-in with phone OTP or Google. On sign-in, guest data is merged into the account and synced across devices.	P1

ID	Feature	Requirement	Priority
F12	Daily reminder	Optional evening notification (default 9 PM) asking to log today's expenses.	P1
F13	Language	English and Hindi at launch, with strings kept in resource files so more languages can be added.	P1
F14	Export	Export expenses as CSV.	P1
F15	Search and filter	Search by item name; filter by date, category and Need/Want.	P2
F16	Recurring expenses	Repeat items such as rent or a subscription on a schedule.	P2

Rules for limits

- A limit is compared with the total of expenses in the current period (week, month or year, in the user's time zone).
- Alert levels are reached once per period per limit, so the user is not warned repeatedly.
- Editing or deleting an expense recalculates progress immediately.
- Warnings are shown in the app first; push notifications for limits are P1.

4. UX principles and key screens

Principles

- Home is the add screen. The first thing a user sees is the amount box.
- Never more than 2 taps or 3 fields for an entry.
- Plain words, big numbers, large tap targets. Readable in sunlight on a low-end phone.
- Show ₹ amounts with Indian grouping (₹1,25,000).
- Messages are kind and short: "You've used 80% of this week's limit."
- Every screen works on a small phone first, then scales to desktop web.

Key screens

Screen	Contents
Home / Add	Amount, item name, Need/Want toggle, Add button, quick-add chips, today's total, last 5 entries, limit bar of the nearest limit
History	Entries grouped by day with day totals; tap to edit, swipe to delete
Report	Weekly summary card with total, top 3 expenses, biggest category, Need vs Want, change vs last week; previous weeks via arrows
Dashboard	Week / Month / Year switch, category chart, daily bars, limit progress bars
Limits	Three optional fields (week, month, year) with on/off toggles
Settings	Language, week start day, reminder time, export, sign in / back up

5. Platform plan, quality targets and rollout

Recommended approach. Build one backend and a responsive web app first (installable as a PWA), then reuse the same REST API for Android and iOS. To avoid writing the app twice, build the mobile apps in React Native or Flutter; React Native shares the most code with a React web app.

Layer	Choice	Why
Web	React + TypeScript, PWA	Fast to build, works offline, installable on phones
Mobile (phase 3)	React Native (or Flutter)	One codebase for Android and iOS
Backend	Node.js (NestJS or Express) REST API	Same language as web, large talent pool

Layer	Choice	Why
Database	MySQL 8 (Amazon RDS in production)	Handles date ranges and totals for reports well; the same MySQL in Workbench and on AWS
Local storage	IndexedDB (web), SQLite (mobile)	Offline-first guest mode
Auth	Phone OTP and Google sign-in, JWT access and refresh tokens	OTP is familiar to Indian users
Hosting	AWS, Mumbai region (ap-south-1): ECS Fargate, RDS, ElastiCache, CloudFront	Lower latency, data stays in India

Non-functional requirements

- Adding an expense completes in under 1 second on a 4G connection and works offline.
- Dashboard and report load in under 2 seconds for one year of data.
- Works on Android 8+, iOS 15+ and the latest two versions of Chrome, Safari, Edge and Firefox.
- All traffic over HTTPS; data encrypted at rest; password-less login only.
- Follows India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act: clear consent, export and account deletion.
- Accessible: contrast ratio of 4.5:1 or better, scalable fonts, screen reader labels.

Release phases

Phase	Scope	Exit goal
1. Web MVP	F1–F10: guest mode, add, chips, categories, need/want, limits, weekly report, dashboard	50 test users log expenses on 5+ days in their first two weeks
2. Accounts and polish	F11–F14: sign-in, sync, reminders, Hindi, CSV export	40% of users return in week 2
3. Mobile apps	Android first, then iOS, using the same API and sync	Store ratings of 4.3 or higher
4. Growth	F15–F16, more languages, widgets, limit push alerts	Based on user feedback

Success metrics

- Median time to add an expense: under 5 seconds.
- Week-2 retention: 40% or more.
- Users who set at least one limit: 50% or more.
- Users who open the weekly report: 60% or more of active users.

Risks

- Users forget to log. Mitigation: reminders, quick-add chips, a very short entry flow.
- Feature creep makes the app complicated. Mitigation: every new feature must pass the "under 5 seconds, no training" test.
- Wrong auto-categories frustrate users. Mitigation: one-tap correction, and learn from the user's own corrections.
- Data loss in guest mode if the browser is cleared. Mitigation: prompt for backup after 7 days of use.

Open questions

- Should the first release be English-only, or include Hindi from day one?
- Is an account required for the web version, or is guest mode enough until phase 2?
- React Native or Flutter for the mobile apps?
- Will the app ever be free with ads, or paid? (The PRD assumes free with no ads.)